



Overall prices of DVD media is expected to come down

R Manikandan, LG

a capacity of 3.95 GB, and DVD-R (G) disks are available in capacities of 4.7GB.

The DVD+R/RW format is relatively new - it became available worldwide only in late 2001. The DVD+R made its appearance in only in mid 2002.

DVD-R/RW and DVD+R/RW media are not compatible with each other. You cannot write DVD-R/RW disks in DVD+R/RW drives and vice versa. This can be quite a hassle and hence manufacturers have come out with dual format DVD drives, which can write to either type of media.

DVD-R media get written at a lower speed than DVD+R media. The theoretical limit for both these type of media is 16X, and a select few DVD+R/RW drives have already reached the limit whereas the DVD-R format is yet to do so. Another reason that makes DVD-R/RW look bad is the finalisation property when writing a disk. Say you want to write a video DVD comprising different clips.

In the case of a DVD-RW disk, you will need to finalise the DVD (marking the lead-in and lead-out) before you can use it on a standalone DVD player. For a DVD+RW disk, this need not be done—it will be compatible with a standard DVD player. This is the DVD+RW VR (DVD+RW Video Recording) feature. DVD-R/RW and DVD+R/RW are compatible with 85 per cent of stand-alone DVD video players.



The Dual-Layer Format

All DVD media available in the market are limited to single layer single sided mode (DVD-5) and can hold up to 4.7 GB of data. Some manufacturers sell dual-sided single layered media (DVD-10), but this is a fast disappearing species since the same amount of data can fit on a single-sided dual layered DVD-9 disk.

Dual layered media has not been available for the general users until now; however, Philips and Mitsubishi Kagaku



Media have developed the DVD+R/RW dual layered media meant for general users. Not to be left behind, Pioneer has released the DVD-R dual layer format for general users, continuing the format wars.

Dual-layer media is still in its infancy since DVD writers that can write on dual layered media cost more than the usual dual-format DVD writers do. Similarly, dual layered media is scarce worldwide and still not freely available in the local market. Another factor is that only the DVD+R/RW format is available in the dual layer format, for now.

For the purists who would rather opt for a dual-format, dual-layer DVD writer there still may be some time to go before you can actually lay your hands on one.

Trends

The market for DVD-Writers is exploding. The average selling price of DVD recorders was expected to fall by as much as 50 per cent in late 2004 as Taiwanese shipments of DVD recorders increased sharply, a government-backed market research firm in Taipei said. Nomura Securities estimated that the global



DVD recorder market would reach \$4.6 billion in 2004, while Pioneer estimates global demand to more than double in 2005 to 8.24 million units from a forecast of 3.6 million units for 2004.

Many users quote compatibility issues—a result of the format wars—as one of the problems they face when making a buying decision. Naturally, all-format recorders, which can record to all DVD media, are the answer.

Says R Manikandan of LG on the major trends in DVDs in 2005: “DVDs will become very popular in 2005. Overall Prices of DVD media is expected to come down owing to volumes spiralling upwards. “DVD writers will become the most popular drive in the market,” he said. “LG offers the world's only all-format DVD-Writer. It is the fastest DVD-Writer at 16X, and can support all the formats in the world.”

The last word comes from Ashmit Shah, a student in Mumbai. He says about his hard disk crash: “My hard disk crashed on me all of a sudden, the way they always seem to do. What in the world would I have done if I had not taken a backup of all my data onto DVDs?”

The point here is that it had taken just about a dozen DVDs and a few hours for the entire backup. ■

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